

**Understanding the Undergraduate Student Fan Experience
at University of Maryland Football Games**

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Introduction

Undergraduate students make up the core part of the student audience at University of Maryland (UMD) football games, and as a result, their attendance attrition noticeably affects the shared fan experience of the population. They pioneer the football traditions and fill up the student section in the stadium, and the atmosphere is expected to be electric, wild, and entertaining. However, there are persisting issues when it comes to this core part of the crowd leaving the stadium during halftime in masses, emptying the student section upon seeing the bad score of our home team, or not willing to stand in an uncomfortable environment for extended periods of time. Most notably, undergraduate students exhibit a behavioral pattern of making key decisions based on social factors, which is central to affecting the attendance rate at football games and reputation of UMD Athletics. Thus, there is a need to improve the social fan experience in order to make the overall game more entertaining, promote football as a more engaging sport, and incentivize audience cohesion to ensure they stay until the end.

The goal of this contextual inquiry study is to understand the fan experience and motivations of specifically UMD undergraduate students at SECU Stadium in regard to football games. In our research, the undergraduate fan experience is generally defined as how factors such as transportation, entertainment, and community affect spectator retention and/or attrition. We collected qualitative data using two different user research methods: contextual interviews and ethnography. Our primary research question to follow throughout our interview and observation questions was: How can UMD Athletics enhance the undergraduate fan experience at home games to increase attendance, retention, and overall satisfaction?

Study Design / Method

Our primary stakeholder for this study was undergraduate students attending the University of Maryland, a community that largely makes up the population of student football attendees at UMD. We utilized two different research methods to gain insight into their experiences: contextual inquiry interviews, and ethnography. The ethnography research method included environment observations, audience immersion, and interviews with attendees at an actual Terps football game. Among our final list of participants included in this study, we recruited a total of 21 undergraduate interviewees of varying majors, grade levels, and ages.

In addition to interview questions centered around the UMD football fan experience, we included background inquiries for their grade level, major, favorite sport, and how those opinions may affect their perception of UMD football games. In the planning stages we recognized the academic intersectionality of the demographic and wanted to investigate the patterns between the different grade levels - freshman, sophomore, junior, and senior. We also acknowledged that the participants' existing biases for or against football and sports in general would inform their overall responses. For instance, we hypothesized that upperclassmen would be attending fewer games/staying at games less compared to lowerclassmen because of having a busier schedule, having more pressing priorities such as job applications, or maybe not being interested in something they might have already done numerous times before.

Our final pool of interviewees was 48% seniors, 14% juniors, 24% sophomores, and 14% freshman; 67% were from a major that is tech or engineering related, 19% were from a major that is art or business related, 14% were from a major that is science related. 24% of participants reported that they were part of a fraternity, but that topic was not part of the interview questions. Using this preliminary data, we hoped to not only aggregate qualitative data about the fan experience, but give specific context and reasoning behind our findings.

Our group conducted two rounds of interviews for contextual inquiry and ethnographic study. Our first round of contextual interviews was conducted over the course of a week, where we recruited undergraduate students who have attended at least one UMD football game during their time at the university. Our method of recruiting interviewees included contacting our inner circle first, then branching out with connections, references, and visiting undergraduate classes for random participants. Overall, our ratio of participants for our first round of contextual interviews was 4 connection-selected interviewees, and 3 randomly selected interviewees.

Our second round of contextual interviews was conducted during our ethnographic observation study at the Terps vs. Rutgers football game on November 16, 2024. Our method of recruiting interviewees included randomly selected participants amongst the audience members sitting in the Student Section of the stadium, as well as seeking out inner circle connections. Overall, our ratio of participants for our second round of interviews was 9 connection selected interviewees, and 5 randomly selected interviewees.

There were limitations to getting the data for undergraduate students, such as temporal constraints (attended a game or multiple games), potential bias in the interviews, and sample representation. For ethnographic research in particular, recruiting random interviewees was dependent on who appeared approachable and open to an interview during the live game, which included factors such as the level of inebriation and rowdiness of an audience member. We acknowledge the internal biases within the interviewers of this session.

Furthermore, during the ethnographic study, we conducted observations within the student section during the Terps vs. Rutgers game. This immersive approach provided valuable insights into the social dynamics and cultural nuances of the UMD undergraduate fan experience. Primarily, we were partaking in and observing the student traditions, chants, and

behaviors, and noting any patterns among those categories that could inform our research and corroborate results from the interviews.

Data Analysis

Process

Observation notes included details about crowd dynamics, seating preferences, and common behaviors, such as when students arrived and left the game. These observations provided context and nuance to complement our interview findings.

Simultaneously, our contextual interviews were audio-recorded to ensure accuracy. Following the interviews, the audio recordings were transcribed, and key points were extracted to align with our research objectives.

All collected data was systematically organized into a comprehensive spreadsheet. This document served as a centralized repository for individual interview responses, observation notes, and connections between raw data and specific research questions. By reviewing and cross-referencing this data, we identified preliminary patterns and trends. The spreadsheet enabled team members to review each other's inputs, ensuring a consistent understanding of the data. This structured approach laid the groundwork for subsequent analysis and the creation of affinity notes.

Interpretation Session

Once data collection was complete, we held interpretation sessions to discuss our findings. These sessions allowed us to reflect on our interview experiences, share insights about undergraduate students' cultural and traditional engagements, and highlight patterns that aligned with the research question.

Key themes emerged during these sessions. One notable finding was the emphasis on community over gameplay; students often prioritized the social and cultural aspects of the event—such as traditions, cheering, and bonding with peers—over the actual football game. This highlighted a significant disconnect between the core sporting activity and its surrounding social experience.

We also observed specific attendance and attrition patterns. Many students arrived late, often missing the start of the game, and left at halftime unless there was a particular incentive to stay, such as the band's performance. Furthermore, while underclassmen tended to display more enthusiasm and engagement, upperclassmen generally showed a declining interest in attending games.

The role of the band emerged as a critical insight. For many attendees, the band was a highlight of the event, often overshadowing the football players' efforts. This demonstrated a potential opportunity to leverage the band's appeal to enhance the overall experience.

Barriers to enjoyment were also extensively discussed. High food and water prices, issues related to alcohol consumption (whether legal or not), and the lack of incentives like student discounts detracted from the experience for many attendees. These factors presented actionable opportunities to address logistical and financial challenges, which could improve satisfaction and retention.

Overall, the interpretation sessions helped us align our findings with the research objectives and provided a deeper understanding of the undergraduate student experience at UMD football games.

Affinity Diagram

To create the affinity diagram, each team member translated interview data into concise yellow sticky notes using direct quotes or summarized observations. These notes were initially color-coded by participants and later standardized into IDs (e.g., P01, P02). Sticky notes were grouped by emerging themes such as "transportation," "seating," and "traditions." This preliminary organization made it easier to manage the growing diagram.

Larger clusters were divided into more specific subgroups. For example, the "traditions" cluster was broken down into smaller groups such as traditions students enjoy, traditions they actively partake in, and their perceptions of certain traditions. This refinement process helped us better understand nuanced behaviors and sentiments.

The affinity diagram was then arranged to follow the user journey, starting with pre-game attitudes and ending with stadium experiences. This logical flow facilitated the identification of actionable insights. High-level insights were captured as pink sticky notes, such as: "Game-day traditions make attendees feel more involved and increase retention due to enhanced school spirit." These notes helped translate raw data into clear takeaways for stakeholders.

Collaborative refinement, both in-person and virtually via Discord, ensured the notes were precise and actionable. This iterative process clarified how traditions, transportation, and other factors influence attendance and retention.

Decision Point Model

We employed the Decision Point Model to visualize the critical factors influencing students' decisions regarding game attendance and retention. This model provided a structured framework to explore dilemmas such as attending or skipping a game and highlighted logistical challenges and cultural influences affecting game-day experiences.

The model illustrated two primary decision pathways: attending or skipping a game and staying until the end or leaving early. Negative factors like transportation issues, inconvenient timing, and poor weather were balanced against positive factors such as anticipation of traditions, social connections, and school pride. Similarly, factors influencing whether students stayed or left early included long game durations and lack of engaging activities, contrasted with engaging traditions and a sense of community.

By mapping these decision points, we identified actionable insights, such as enhancing transportation options and introducing engaging in-game activities to counter negative experiences. The model aligns with our goal of improving undergraduate students' experiences, providing stakeholders with a clear understanding of barriers and opportunities for enhancing game-day engagement.

Results/Findings

Upon completion of data collection and analysis through our affinity diagram and interpretation sessions, we found several key insights that reveal the attitudes and motivations of undergraduate students when it comes to UMD football games. Our affinity diagram, as seen on our portfolio, demonstrates the different overarching themes and sub-themes found throughout our interview responses. One of our largest findings was that undergraduate students deeply depend on the social aspects of football games in determining what games they attend, their duration of stay, and their overall enjoyment.

Many students attend football games as a reason to hang out with friends, whether that be at the actual game, or before the game at tailgates. While attending the November 16th

game against Rutgers, we observed that many of the students in the student section opted to chat with friends and take pictures during the game – sometimes even standing with their backs turned toward the field. This demonstrates a lack of engagement in the actual gameplay, and shows that students utilize the games to talk with friends. Additionally, we received responses that indicated many students would not go to a game at all if they did not have anyone to go with, and would leave the game if their friends were, despite any personal preference to stay.

Another important insight we found was that when students attend games, they often leave during or after halftime. This is due to a few factors, including wide score margins, long length of stoppages and games, unengaging halftime shows, lack of football knowledge and/or enjoyment of football culture, and overall disconnect from or loss of interest in the progression of the game. Participants indicated that when one team is winning or losing by a large margin by halftime, they are more likely to leave – especially if the losing team is Maryland. Their reasoning for this is because the gameplay becomes less exciting and competitive, and by that point, they feel they already know the outcome.

Some participants also indicated that despite how the game is going, they still typically leave at halftime due to the length. On average, a college football game is 3 hours and 22 minutes long, per Parks (2023). Students become tired, and would rather leave the game early to watch the rest of the game on TV or look up the score later. This tiredness could be attributed to the culture of the student section, which is where all of our participants noted they sit, as well as hunger. In the student section, people stand for the majority of the game, aside from halftime. Students also said that because concession prices are high and they are not allowed to bring food in the stadium, they do not eat or purchase anything. This is a very long time for students to be standing and hungry, especially if they began their game day early by tailgating, and therefore influences them to leave the game prematurely.

Unengaging halftime shows also impact students' decisions to leave the game. Many students emphasized that the band, cheerleaders, dancers, and other entertainment are their favorite part of football games, but also stated they noticed that halftime shows were not geared towards them. When the band performs at halftime, they face a different section of the stadium, and are difficult to hear from where the majority of students sit. One participant even inquired about if the band plays during halftime at all. This demonstrates a disconnect between the student section and the halftime entertainment, and influences students to lose investment in the game.

Lastly, we found that students who do not generally engage with football and the culture that surrounds it are more likely to leave early, or simply not attend games at all. Many participants of our research mentioned that they often lose interest in the games they attend as they do not understand what is happening. These students expressed a desire to know more about how football works, but did not know where to start. Additionally, students who do not enjoy the rowdiness, vulgar language use, and drinking aspects surrounding the sport were more likely to express frustrations and unhappiness with their experiences at games. They expressed preferences to be able to sit and enjoy the game, without being around people screaming expletives or acting inebriated.

When it comes to choosing what games to go to, we found that undergraduate students prefer games where the opponent is a big name and/or rival university, such as Penn State. The prospect of a rivalry encourages students to engage in school pride and feel more of a personal stake in the outcome of the game. The high-energy and community aspect of these games are appealing to students, and keep them interested in the gameplay. Other events that aid in creating community and high energy for students include popular music, giveaways, themed nights, mini-games to win prizes, and attention given to the student section by players and

Testudo. These events engage students and get them excited to attend as part of a collective, passionate group.

Utilizing the themes found through affinity diagramming, we created two decision-point models to demonstrate the factors that influence undergraduate students to leave or stay at a particular game, and which games to attend. Additionally, we created a persona to exhibit the typical user demographics, behaviors, needs, etc. of undergraduate students as it relates to their fan experience at football games. These models help us better understand what UMD Athletics could do to improve the attitudes and attendance of undergraduates at the football games.

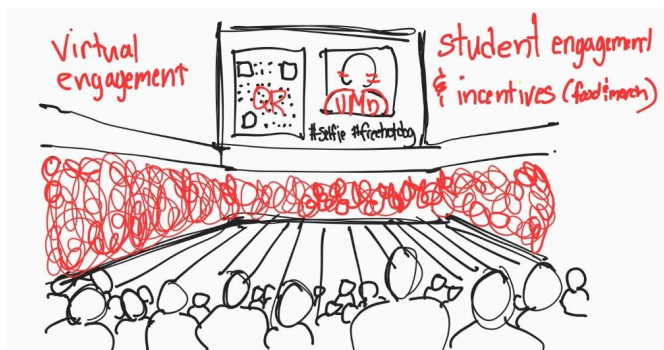
Implications

The Wall Walk engagement provided comprehensive insights into enhancing the undergraduate student fan experience at UMD football games. By analyzing key findings from our research, we identified actionable implications to address significant pain points and amplify motivators for attendance, engagement, and retention. These implications focus on fostering a stronger sense of community, improving logistical elements, and enriching entertainment experiences to create a cohesive and engaging game-day experience.

Design Idea 1: Enhanced Halftime Experience

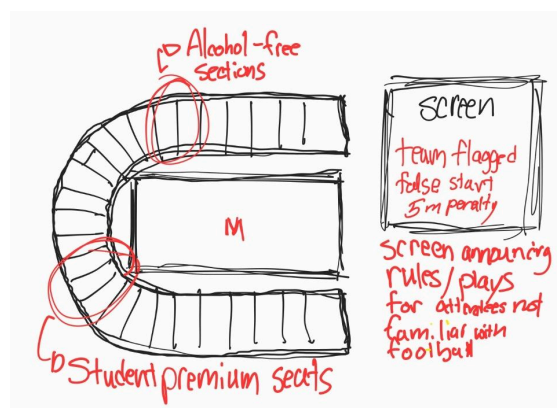
This idea aims to transform the halftime segment into a more interactive and immersive experience, specifically tailored to resonate with the student section and their preferences. Key elements include:

- **Social Media Integration:** Students will have the opportunity to share their game-day experiences through social media platforms by tagging posts and selfies with designated



hashtags, fostering a sense of inclusion and community. This feature not only encourages social engagement but also boosts the visibility of UMD football games among broader networks, promoting school pride.

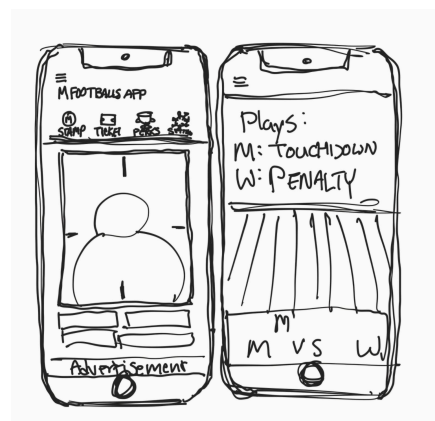
- Interactive Engagement Opportunities:** Students can participate in live challenges accessed through QR codes displayed on the stadium screens. These challenges might include love polls, etc. The prizes may include UMD merchandise or food vouchers. By actively involving students in the halftime experience, this strategy keeps the student section engaged and entertained during longer breaks.
- Student Premium Seating:** A designated seating section for students will be introduced adjacent to the season ticket holders. This section will provide improved views of the field and performances, offering students a taste of the experience associated with season ticket seating. Students may feel more included in the stadium's focal events. This approach fosters long-term loyalty by encouraging students to envision themselves as future season ticket holders post-graduation.
- Dry Zone, Alcohol-Free:** A specific alcohol-free section within the student area will be created to accommodate students and their guests who prefer a quieter, family-friendly atmosphere. This Dry Zone will reduce disruptions caused by intoxicated attendees and create an environment more conducive to enjoying the gameplay and fostering positive experiences.



By implementing these enhancements, the halftime experience can become a central highlight of the game, addressing the common issue of students leaving early and fostering greater retention throughout the game's duration

Design Idea 2: Gamified Football Engagement App

A UMD-branded mobile application will be developed to gamify the football experience and encourage sustained engagement from students. This app will provide a comprehensive, interactive platform to enhance game-day participation. Key features include:



- Attendance and Engagement Tracking:** Students can earn points for attending games and staying through each quarter. Points will scale with sustained attendance, rewarding those who stay until the end of the game.
- Interactive Participation Features:** Halftime events mentioned above such as live polls, halftime challenges, and posting photos that students can engage with during the game will be featured on the app. By integrating these features with a point-based reward system, students are encouraged to actively participate and stay connected with the game-day experience.
- Reward Redemption System:** Points accumulated through attendance and participation can be redeemed for exclusive rewards, such as discounted season tickets, exclusive UMD gear, food vouchers, etc. This reward system creates tangible incentives for students to stay engaged and build loyalty to the program.
- Streamlined Ticketing and Information:** This app will allow students to purchase tickets, manage attendance, and access essential information such as schedules,

stadium maps, and game-day events. This feature simplifies logistical challenges and enhances the overall convenience of attending football games.

This gamified approach leverages students' affinity for digital engagement and social interaction, ensuring a dynamic, rewarding, and tech-forward experience that aligns with their behaviors and preferences.

Conclusion

Over the course of our contextual and ethnographic research, it was revealed that there are social and accessibility-related setbacks when it comes to fulfilling the undergraduate fan experience, especially as they make up the majority of the student body at football games. Undergraduate students leave during halftime because of their typical experience journey - they lose interest in the game because they don't understand the rules and they only judge based on the team winning or losing, the student section is crowded and uncomfortable to sit in, and their frustrations with a lack of consistent stimulation over an extended period of time cause them and their friends to leave as a group.

However, even with these drawbacks, they're initially drawn to football games because of the energizing atmosphere of game day, the school spirit of football traditions and culture, and socializing with other people to make friends or strengthen relationships. Thus, there is a high potential to leverage the social factors to an undergraduate student's motivations for attending and staying at UMD football games. They value the games as opportunities for camaraderie and school pride, and the data collected from all interviews and observations guides the strategy for

enhancing the entertainment experience, improving attendance, and ensuring a more enjoyable environment for everybody.

To enhance the fan experience, the University can implement marketing, environmental, and product strategies that increase engagement at football games and leverage the existing sense of community. Our implications offer such solutions with opportunities for more physical and virtual involvement. By offering diverse entertainment options beyond traditional halftime shows, UMD can encourage group attendance and create shared experiences among students. Additionally, providing real-time explanations of good plays and penalties can deepen understanding of the game, stimulating discussion and increasing fan retention. Finally, incentivizing attendance through rewards can create a positive feedback loop, motivating students to attend games regularly and build stronger social connections.

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